Kristen Steffler Varona

602.400.2943 | Scottsdale, AZ | kristenvarona@gmail.com Portfolio | LinkedIn | GitHub

Engineering Manager | Product-Minded Engineering Leader | SaaS | Platform Modernization

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Engineering leader who has hired, coached, and managed engineering teams of up to eight, delivered a 14-month enterprise platform modernization, and built a patented SaaS product from zero as CTO.

I set clear priorities, partner with architects and technical leads on direction, and stay close enough to the code to review architecture and pull requests. I have led teams across onshore, offshore, and contract arrangements, managed engineering budgets, and made the hard personnel decisions when they were needed.

At Plexus Worldwide, I took over the DevOps team with a four-year stalled modernization program, established the delivery structure from scratch, and shipped the full initiative in fourteen months while absorbing an unplanned market expansion and rebuild of lower environments. At Kanban Zone, I hired the team, managed the engineering budget, and built a workflow SaaS into a patented, profitable platform, writing code, using Terraform, running CI/CD, and reviewing every engineer's code along the way.

Thirty years across enterprise retail technology, SaaS, and e-commerce.

CORE SKILLS

Leadership Team Leadership | Hiring & Interviewing | Coaching & Mentoring | Performance Management | Budget Ownership | Cross-Functional Partnership | Stakeholder Management
Engineering & Delivery Architecture & Code Review | Delivery Forecasting & Lean Metrics | Roadmap & Backlog Prioritization | Release Management | Agile/Scrum | Dependency Management
Technical MERN Stack | AWS | Terraform | Jenkins CI/CD | APIs & System Integration | Platform Architecture | Data Modeling | SQL | Event-Driven Systems | AI/ML Integration
Tools Jira | Confluence | GitHub | Jenkins | Terraform | PostHog | Full Story | Figma | Claude | OpenAI APIs
Domain Retail Technology | POS Systems | E-Commerce | Subscription, Payments & Reconciliation | SaaS Platforms | Enterprise Software | Regulatory Compliance

EXPERIENCE

Business Wire, a Berkshire Hathaway Company
Technical Product Manager | Aug 2026 – Present | Remote
Global leader in multiplatform news release distribution.

TrailOS (trailos.app)
Founder & Product Architect | Feb 2026 – Present
Summary: Founded and built a two-product, AI-native outdoor adventure SaaS suite, WildLog and TripForge, plus Field Notes, a companion iOS app now live on the App Store. Shipped end-to-end as a solo founder.

- Made architecture, scope, and sequencing decisions across a web product suite and an iOS companion app, and delivered both live and fully integrated.
- Built AI-powered features, including report generation that turns raw trail notes into shareable trip

reports and destination recommendations based on user history.
- Took Field Notes from field testing to App Store launch in Oct 2026, with off-grid capabilities that syncs back to WildLog.
- Instrumented analytics, SEO, and user insights from launch and iterated on customer feedback.

Plexus Worldwide
Manager, DevOps | May 2024 – July 2025
Summary: Led the DevOps team for an enterprise-wide platform modernization with eight direct reports across onshore, offshore, and contract arrangements. Rescued a four-year stalled program and delivered it in 14 months while absorbing a concurrent rebuild of environments and a separate market expansion.

- Managed eight direct reports (six engineers, an architect, and a release manager) across onshore, offshore, and contract arrangements, owning performance evaluations, raises, and growth planning.
- Hired with HR and recruiters, conducting culture-fit and technical interviews for my team and for peer hires and other teams, including Engineering and QA. Converted an intern to a full-time hire.
- Coached and mentored through regular 1:1s, setting growth goals and creating development opportunities for each team member.
- Addressed underperformance directly with documented expectations and performance improvement plans, working with HR on personnel decisions when improvement did not come.
- Participated in budget planning for my team's portion of the program budget.
- Led the critical-path modernization through full production readiness in 14 months by establishing a cohesive technical roadmap and sequencing execution across the distributed team.
- Built the technical backlog from zero, translating business priorities into structured epics, sequencing, and execution plans.
- Delivered a last-minute Japan market expansion on schedule with minimal impact to the core timeline by re-sequencing parallel workstreams and managing dependencies across logistics, e-commerce, and direct sales systems.
- Improved release cadence and delivery predictability by 50% by strengthening Agile practices and establishing consistent production deployment cycles.
- Partnered daily with peers in the PMO, Development, Architecture, QA, and Help Desk, and aligned executive leadership on competing priorities and delivery expectations.

Kanban Zone LLC (kanbanzone.com)
Co-Founder, CTO & Product Architect | Jan 2017 – Oct 2023
Summary: Co-founded and scaled a B2B SaaS workflow platform from zero to a patented, profitable product, leading engineering, architecture, and product decisions for seven years. Grew to 3,000+ users on a bootstrapped budget with a high-velocity daily deployment cadence.

- Found, interviewed, and hired a cross-functional team of up to five across engineering, QA, and UI/UX, and worked side by side with them in a hands-on environment.
- Managed the entire engineering budget for a bootstrapped company.
- Reviewed code daily for every engineer and ran the day-to-day Jenkins CI/CD pipelines, sustaining a high-velocity release cadence.
- Wrote production code in the MERN stack on AWS, including infrastructure as code with Terraform.
- Owned architecture and data modeling for the complete SaaS platform, including API design and the patented flexible board engine.
- Set product and engineering roadmaps and strategy and delivered on a continuous cadence, making build-vs-buy decisions and delivery trade-offs across product quality, scope, and timeline.
- Worked directly with customers, sales, and support, using beta programs, usage telemetry, and customer feedback to drive prioritization, subscription and add-on monetization, and usability improvements.

Office Depot Latin America
Contract, Retail Systems SME (POS & Regulatory Systems) | February 2019 – February 2023
Summary: Owned delivery and technical maintenance for a multi-country POS platform across three retail chains in Latin America, each with distinct codebases and regulatory requirements, with zero disruption to revenue-critical store operations.

- Owned delivery of POS payment, tax, and compliance systems across Office Depot, RadioShack, and Marchand, from client requirements through production rollout.
- Delivered enhancements, defect fixes, and regulatory updates with zero disruption to store operations, on a platform that integrated cash drawers, printers, and pole displays.
- Advised on integration architecture and rollout strategy for next-generation POS systems, bridging legacy constraints with modern retail and payment capabilities.

Blue Drop Solutions LLC
Technical Product Consultant | Product & Engineering Delivery | Transformations | May 2011 – March 2024
Summary: Delivered product and engineering transformation engagements for enterprise clients, including American Express, Best Western International, SkyTouch, and Blue Cross Blue Shield of Arizona. Led a full-scale agile and DevOps transformation at Best Western, restructuring the technology organization from waterfall to continuous delivery.

- Provided executive advisory to senior leadership on delivery prioritization and organizational operating model design across enterprise technology environments.
- Delivered enterprise transformation engagements across fintech, healthcare, hospitality, and retail clients, including American Express, Blue Cross Blue Shield of Arizona, and CSAA.
- Led a technology and delivery transformation at Best Western International, restructuring teams into cross-functional delivery units and moving the organization from waterfall to continuous delivery.
- Introduced scaled Kanban, DevOps practices, and test automation to improve delivery flow, predictability, and engineering throughput across distributed teams.

JDA Software (now Blue Yonder)
Software Engineer → Technical Lead / Architect | June 1998 – 2009
Summary: Spent over a decade building enterprise retail platforms, including POS, replenishment, pricing, loyalty, and payment systems for major North American and Latin American retailers. Progressed from consulting engineer to technical lead and architect.

- Served as Scrum Master and technical team lead while progressing from consulting engineer to architect across POS, replenishment, and logistics platforms in production.
- Reduced pricing synchronization time from 7 hours to under 10 minutes by identifying performance bottlenecks and redesigning the central-office-to-store batch execution path, delivered solo.
- Architected and led delivery for a large-scale retail replenishment platform that coordinated inventory and demand logic across distributed retail networks for Tier-1 North American retailers.
- Delivered custom point-of-sale enhancements for major North American retailers, including pricing, tax, compliance, loyalty, and payment systems, working directly with clients from requirements through production rollout.